The Throne of Fire

By Rick Riordan

**NOTE: Sadie and Liz should have pronounced British accents*

Nekhbet appears as a woman that is a hundred years old. The skin around her face, neck, and earlobes sag and her body is hunched over and emaciated. She is almost bald, with just a few clumps of greasy black hair on her head. She wears a "lush" black dress made entirely of feathers

I'd never been in a limousine before. I hope most are nicer than the one we took. The backseat was littered with take-away curry containers, old fish-and-chip paper, crisps bags, and various dirty socks. Despite this, Liz and I crammed together in the back, because neither of us dared ride up front.

You may think I was mad to get in a car with a strange man. You're right, of course. But the gods had promised us help and a driver. The fact that our promised help was a little man with bad hygiene and a magical limousine did not particularly surprise me. I'd seen stranger things.

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INTRODUCTION

Of course Sadie had seen stranger things . . . that tends to happen when you are one of the most powerful descendants of the ancient Egyptian pharaohs to be born in centuries!

Sadie is on a mission to revive the sun god Ra who can stop the god of Chaos and his minions from rising and destroying the world. (Where was she when we needed her in the years leading up to the 2016 Presidential Election?)

In this selection, Sadie finds an ally in Bes, the dwarf god (Think Tirian Lannister from Game of Thrones), who helps her defeat two of Chaos' minions: Nekhbet, the Vulture Goddess, and Babi, a blood-thirsty god of the underworld.

Will Sadie and Bes prevail or will Chaos reign? Throne of Fire by Rick Riordan.

He was shorter than me by half, and uglier than anyone else on the planet. His facial features were positively Neanderthal. Under his thick furry mono-brow, one eye was bigger than the other. His beard looked as if it had been used to scrape greasy pots. His skin was poxy with red welts, and his hair looked like a bird's nest that had been set on fire then stomped out.

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When he saw me, he scowled, which did nothing to help his appearance.

BES: About time! *(American accent, belching into his fist).* Sadie Kane?

SADIE: Um . . . possibly. By the way, we have two gods trying to kill us.

BES: *(Turning toward the curb and yelling,)* BOO!

SADIE: *(To Audience)* A black Mercedes limousine appeared out of nowhere, as if it had been scared into existence.

BES: *(Glancing at Sadie and arching his brow.)* Well? Get in!

The chauffeur started whistling a tune that sounded like "Short People." His head barely reached the headrest. All I could see of him was a grubby nest of hair and a set of furry hands on the wheel.

Stuck in the sun visor was an identification card with his picture – sort of. It had been taken at point-blank range, showing only an out-of-focus nose and a hideous mouth, as if he'd been trying to eat the camera.

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The card read: Your Driver is BES. *(To Bes)* You're Bes, I guess?

BES: Yes.

SADIE: Your car's a mess.

LIZ: If one more person rhymes, I'll throw up.

SADIE: *(To Bes)* Is it Mr. Bes? *(To Audience)* I tried to place his name from Egyptian mythology. I was fairly sure they hadn't had a god of chauffeurs. *(To Bes)* Lord Bes? Bes the Extremely Short?

BES: Just Bes. One "S". And no, it's NOT a girl's name. Call me Bessie, and I'll have to kill you. As for being short, I'm the dwarf god, so what do you expect? Oh, there's bottled water for you back there if you're thirsty.

SADIE: *(To Audience)* Rolling about at my feet were two partially empty bottles of water. One had lipstick on the cap. The other looked as if it had been chewed on. *(To Bes)* Not thirsty.

LIZ: You're really a god?

BES: Huge! I'm *huge* in the world of gods.

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LIZ: A huge god of dwarves. You mean as in Snow White, or –

BES: All dwarves. Egyptians were smart. They honored people who were born unusual. Dwarves were considered extremely magical. So yeah, I'm the god of dwarves.

LIZ: *(clearing her throat.)* Isn't there a more polite term we're supposed to use nowadays? Like . . . little person, or vertically challenged, or –

BES: I'm not going to call myself the god of vertically challenged people. I'm a dwarf! Now, here we are just in time.

He spun the car to a stop in the middle of the bridge. Looking behind us, I almost lost the contents of my stomach. A winged black shape was circling over the riverbank. At the end of the bridge, Babi was taking care of the barricade in his own fashion. He was throwing police cars into the River Thames while the officers scattered and fired their weapons, though the

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bullets seemed to have no effect on the baboon god's steely fur. *(to Liz)* Liz, we're getting out.

LIZ: *(whimpering)* Getting. . . out?

BES: *(stifling a yawn.)* Need my help?

SADIE: Um . . . *(To audience)* Babi was lumbering towards us. Nekhbet circled over him, shrieking orders. I didn't see how a dwarf god could stand against those two, but, *(To Bes)* Yes, I need help.

BES: Right. *(cracking his knuckles.)* So get out.

SADIE: What?

BES: I can't change clothes with you in the car, can I? I have to put on my ugly outfit.

SADIE: Ugly outfit?

BES: Go! I'll be out in a minute.

It didn't take much encouragement. Neither of us wanted to see any more of Bes than we had to. We got out, and Bes locked the doors behind us. The windows were heavily tinted, so I couldn't see in. For all

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I knew Bes would be relaxing, listening to music while we got slaughtered. I certainly didn't have much hope that a wardrobe change was going to defeat Nekhbet and Babi. *(To Liz and Bes)* We'll make our last stand here.

LIZ: Oh, no, no. I really don't like the term "last stand."

SADIE: *(To Audience)* Nekhbet must've seen the desperation in my face. She was a vulture. She specialized in knowing when her prey was finished.

NEKHBET: A good last effort child, but you have nothing left. Babi, attack!

SADIE: *(To Audience)* The baboon god reared up on his back legs. I got ready to charge and deliver one final burst of energy – to tap into my own life source and hopefully vaporize the gods. Then the limo's door opened behind me.

BES: No one is attacking anyone! Except me, of course.

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SADIE: *(To Audience)* Nekhbet shrieked in alarm. I turned to see what was going on. Immediately, I wished I could burn my eyes out of my head.

LIZ: *(making a gagging sound.)* Lord, no! That's *wrong*! Make him stop!

Bes had indeed put on his ugly outfit. He climbed onto the roof of the limo and stood there, legs planted, arms akimbo, like Superman – except with only the underwear.

For those faint of heart, I won't go into great detail, but Bes, all of a meter tall, was showing off his disgusting physique – his potbelly, hairy limbs, awful feet, gross flabby bits – and wearing only a blue Speedo. Imagine the worst looking person you've ever seen on a public beach – the person for whom swimwear should be illegal. Bes looked worse than that. *(To Bes)* Put on some clothes!

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BES: *(laughing loudly in a sort of guffaw that says "Ha-ha! I'm amazing!")* Not until they leave. Or I'll be forced to scare them away.

NEKHBET: This is not your affair, dwarf god! *(snarling and averting her eyes from his hideousness.)* Go away!

BES: These children are under my protection.

SADIE: I don't know you! I never met you before today.

BES: Nonsense. You expressly asked for my protection.

SADIE: I didn't ask for the Speedo Patrol!

Bes leaped off the limo and landed in front of me, placing himself between Babi and me. The dwarf was even more horrible from behind. His back was so hairy it looked like a mink coat. And on the back of his Speedo was printed DWARF PRIDE.

Bes and Babi circled each other like wrestlers. The baboon god swiped at Bes, but the dwarf was agile. He scrambled up Babi's chest and head-butted him in

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the nose. Babi staggered backward as the dwarf continued pounding away, using his face as a deadly weapon.

Babi slumped against the railing. He blinked, trying to regain his bearings, but Bes breathed on him, and the smell of curry must've been too much. The baboon's knees buckled. His body shimmered and began to shrink. Then Bes turned toward the vulture goddess.

BES: Now it's your turn, Nekhbet. *Leave.*

NEKHBET: I stole this body fair and square! *(wailing)* I like it in here!

BES: You asked for it.

Bes rubbed his hands, took a deep breath, and did something I will never be able to erase from my memory. If I simply said he made a face and yelled BOO, that would be technically correct, but it wouldn't begin to convey the horror. His head swelled. His jaw unhinged until his mouth was four times too big. His eyes bulged like grapefruits. His hair stuck straight up. He shook

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his face and waggled his slimy green tongue and roared BOOOO! so loudly, the sound rolled across the Thames like a cannon shot. This blast of pure ugly blew the feathers off Nekhbet's cloak and drained all the color from her face. It ripped away the essence of the goddess like tissue paper in a storm. The dwarf's face went back to normal – well, normal *ugly*, at least – *(To Bes)* Thank you. Now, will you please put on some clothes? *(To Audience)* He gave me a toothy grin, which I could have lived without.

BES: You're all right, Sadie Kane.

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